Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Proverbs

Proverbs 1:1

Solomon is the authority on Israelite wisdom (see 1 Kings 3:1–28; 4:32). Many proverbs are attributed to Solomon, but he did not write all of them (see Proverbs 22:17; 24:23; 25:1; 30:1; 31:1).

Proverbs 1:2–3

Wisdom is practical knowledge that involves ethical choices. Words like right, just, and fair are associated with biblical wisdom. Gaining wisdom requires discipline, which means actively and intentionally training yourself toward wisdom and away from foolishness. The book of Proverbs encourages us to resist our natural sinful tendencies toward wrong behavior.

Proverbs 1:2–7

This introduction explains the book's purpose and identifies the different audiences it addresses.

Proverbs 1:4

Simple people are like empty containers. Wisdom and foolishness compete to fill their minds and hearts (see Proverbs 9:1–18).

Proverbs 1:6

Proverbs help wise people understand riddles. Here the Hebrew word (khidoth) means enigmas or paradoxes—difficult sayings that need interpretation (see Judges 14:14).

Proverbs 1:7

Fear of the Lord means relying completely on God for everything, including knowledge and wisdom (Proverbs 9:10). It is not just a way of thinking; it involves serving, loving, and obeying God's laws (see Deuteronomy 10:12–13). Fear of the Lord is the basis of all knowledge. How can we understand life without knowing its most basic truth—that God created it?

Proverbs 1:8–19

In the book of Proverbs, there are two paths (Proverbs 1:15):

- A wise and just path
- A foolish and evil path

The parents represent the wise path and encourage their child to follow it.

Proverbs 1:8–9.18

my son: Like other wisdom literature from the ancient Near East, much of Proverbs 1–9 contains a father's (and sometimes a mother's) advice to a son. Since the son is learning his father's job, much of the teaching is about the son's future work. Some translations (like The New Living Translation) often use the term child because the lessons apply to both sons and daughters.

Proverbs 1:9

garland of grace... pendant: Ornaments often symbolize wisdom and its rewards (see also Proverbs 3:22; 4:9). This imagery encourages people to seek wisdom with effort.

Proverbs 1:10–19

The father warns his child not to join a group of wrongdoers planning to attack innocent people. Their evil actions will eventually harm them (see Proverbs 28:10; Psalms 9:15; 35:8). The evil path involves violence and theft.

Proverbs 1:12

like Sheol: In the Old Testament, Sheol is the place of the dead. It is not always associated with punishment.

Proverbs 1:17–19

Birds avoid obvious traps, but greedy people do not. When they choose violence and robbery, they risk losing their lives violently. They might die during the crime or be punished with death if caught. Even if wrongdoers succeed until they die, they will experience judgment after death, while the righteous will be with God (see Psalm 1).

Proverbs 1:20–33

The author describes wisdom as a woman. In Hebrew, the word for wisdom, khokmah, is grammatically feminine. The author encourages his son to embrace wisdom (see Proverbs 3:18; 8:1–9:6).

Proverbs 1:22

Proverbs uses three main words to describe those who lack God's wisdom:

- Simple ones (Hebrew pethim) have not rejected God's wisdom and are most open to correction (see Proverbs 1:4).
- Fools (Hebrew kesilim) have heard God's wisdom but resist it.
- Scoffers (Hebrew latsonim) not only resist wisdom but also ridicule it.

Proverbs 1:23

Wisdom invites all three groups to come so she can make them wise (Proverbs 1:22). Having a close relationship with Wisdom means beginning a close relationship with God, which is the basis of true knowledge (Proverbs 1:7; see Job 28).

Proverbs 1:24–27

you neglected all my counsel: This is like ignoring God's call (see Psalm 14). God calls us through:

- creation (Psalm 8; Romans 1:18–20)
- Scripture (2 Timothy 3:16–17; 2 Peter 1:20–21)

Proverbs 1:28

I will not answer: If someone has not sought wisdom before trouble comes, it is often too late to learn.

Proverbs 1:29–30

they hated knowledge: Proverbs uses strong language. You either love and accept Wisdom or hate and reject her.

Proverbs 1:31

People who do wrong will face the results of their actions (see Proverbs 1:15–19). God will make sure that sinners get the proper punishment (see Matthew 25:44–46; Hebrews 10:29; 2 Peter 2:9).

Proverbs 1:33

Wise people do not fear. They trust that God is in control, and wisdom helps them deal with every situation.

Proverbs 2:1

hide my commandments: This means to pay attention to them and follow them. They allow us to fully enjoy and experience life.

Proverbs 2:1–22

The father advises his son to seek wisdom. It will protect him from bad people and the risks of unfaithful women. The son should pursue wisdom, knowing it is a gift from God.

Proverbs 2:2–3

wisdom…understanding…insight: These three words are skills needed to handle life's challenges.

Proverbs 2:4

People search for silver or hidden treasures with urgency, excitement, and hope for a reward (see Matthew 13:44; Luke 15:8–10).

Proverbs 2:5

The search for true wisdom leads to God. You cannot have wisdom without the fear of the Lord (having a great reverence, honor, and respect for God) (Proverbs 1:7).

Proverbs 2:6

The Lord gives wisdom to those who learn it from the Scriptures, which are his words (2 Timothy 3:16; 2 Peter 1:20–21). You cannot become wise through observation alone.

Proverbs 2:7–8

Here, common sense is the natural understanding gained by listening to God's words and observing his world. God acts as a shield, guarding and protecting those who have a relationship with him.

Proverbs 2:10

- Wisdom will enter your heart and become a key part of your life. Instead of sometimes doing wise things, a wise person always makes wise choices.
- Knowledge brings joy because it helps people live well.

Proverbs 2:12–15

- Wisdom knows when people alter words to make wrong things seem right. The right path leads to life, while the wrong path leads to death (Proverbs 1:10–19; 2:18–19; 5:5–6; 9:1–6, 13–18).
- ways of darkness: In the New Testament, darkness represents evil, while light represents God's goodness (Matthew 4:16; 5:14–16; John 1:14; Romans 2:19).

Proverbs 2:16

Wisdom helps a young man avoid an immoral woman, enabling him to resist her flattering and seductive words. Wisdom involves emotional maturity, self-control, and understanding the intent behind someone's words.

Proverbs 2:17

An immoral woman has left her husband to pursue another man. Her marriage vows before God included promises of faithfulness (see Malachi 2:14–16).

Proverbs 2:18–19

sinks…to the departed spirits: Adultery breaks a key promise to one's spouse and to God (see also Genesis 39:2–9; Malachi 2:14).

Proverbs 2:20–22

Those who make wise choices will live in the land; those who do not will be evicted. God gave the land of Israel to his people, but they could only stay if they followed God's commands (Deuteronomy 28:9–11, 64–68). Because they broke his law, they were expelled in 586 BC (see 2 Kings 25:1–30; 2 Chronicles 36:15–21).

Proverbs 3:1

Storing God's commands in your heart means more than memorizing them. It involves making them a key part of your life and acting on them.

Proverbs 3:1–12

The Lord blesses people who trust him and seek his guidance. His correction helps those who follow him.

Proverbs 3:2

People who follow God's laws often live longer. Wickedness usually harms both body and mind. However, sometimes evil people live longer than good people (Ecclesiastes 7:15–18).

Proverbs 3:3

- Loyalty and kindness show God's deep and complete commitment to his covenant with his people (see Deuteronomy 6:8–9).
- write them: For a similar command, see Proverbs 7:3.

Proverbs 3:5–6

On the journey to wisdom, God guides us through the wisdom in his word.

Proverbs 3:8

Healing and strength mean enjoying physical energy as God's reward for following the path of wisdom.

Proverbs 3:9–10

God receives honor and blesses his people when they acknowledge him as the source of all they have. He blesses them when they give him the best part of everything they produce (Genesis 4:3–5; 18:6; Numbers 18:12, 29).

Proverbs 3:11–12

The Lord's discipline can include hardships, disappointments, and frustrations (see Hebrews 12:4–6). Like a good father, God aims to make us wise, good, and happy.

Proverbs 3:13

Wisdom and understanding help you live well and solve life's problems.

Proverbs 3:14–15

Wisdom is more valuable than precious metals and jewels. It leads to a relationship with God, who gives ultimate joy (see Proverbs 2:1–8).

Proverbs 3:18

The tree of life refers to the first tree in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:9).

Proverbs 3:19–20

God's wisdom brought harmony to the universe. Being wise means living according to the principles found in creation.

Proverbs 3:21–26

This passage lists the benefits of common sense and discernment, which come from wisdom.

Proverbs 3:27–28

A wise person is a kind and helpful neighbor. Proverbs strongly emphasizes helping those in financial need (Proverbs 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14).

Proverbs 3:29

Since we often interact with our neighbors, we should not exploit them.

Proverbs 3:30

While we cannot avoid all conflict, we should not start fights.

Proverbs 3:31–32

Those who use violence will eventually face punishment for their actions (Proverbs 1:18–32), even if they appear successful in the world (11:16). The wise will not envy them, as they are disliked by the Lord. God's friendship offers much more than anything the violent can gain.

Proverbs 4:1

- Discourses in Proverbs 1–9 often start with a call to listen (compare 1:8, 23; 2:1; 4:20–21; 5:1–2; 6:20–23; 7:1–3).
- Listen…to a father's instruction: Children should listen because they have made mistakes.

Proverbs 4:2

Wise people handle life's challenges well because they follow good advice.

Proverbs 4:3

a son to my father…the only child of my mother: In Proverbs, both parents teach wisdom. This joint involvement is unique in ancient Near Eastern traditions.

Proverbs 4:4

my commands: The words that describe a father's teaching are also used in Scripture for God's law. Fathers represent God to their children. Wise fathers' teachings align with God's law.

Proverbs 4:5

In the Old Testament, forgetting means more than just not remembering; it also means failing to obey.

Proverbs 4:6

she: In Proverbs, the text sometimes describes wisdom as a woman (see Proverbs 1:20–33; 8:1–9:6).

Proverbs 4:7–8

Wisdom often leads to better relationships and more wealth, but not always.

Proverbs 4:9

A lovely wreath and a beautiful crown symbolize the rewards of wisdom (see also Proverbs 1:9 and 3:22).

Proverbs 4:10

Not every wise person lives longer than every evil person. However, obedience and wise living increase the chances of a long, good life (see also Proverbs 5:1–14, 21–23; 23:29–35; compare Ecclesiastes 2:12217).

Proverbs 4:10–19

The father offers his children two choices:

- Avoid evil to escape its bad effects
- Choose good for its blessings

Proverbs 4:11–12

- Wisdom's paths are straightforward (honest), while a fool's paths are dishonest (Proverbs 2:15).
- When you walk…run: the wise achieve their goals faster and more efficiently.

Proverbs 4:16

The wicked stay up at night to plan evil deeds (Psalm 36:4; Micah 2:1).

Proverbs 4:17

To eat wickedness and drink violence means these traits are central to someone's life. Just as we eat and drink to live, evil people sustain themselves by doing evil acts.

Proverbs 4:18–19

Light symbolizes wisdom and righteousness, while darkness represents foolishness and wickedness (see Ecclesiastes 2:12–14). Light reveals actions; darkness conceals them. Righteous people have nothing to hide, but the wicked try to hide their actions and stumble over obstacles in the dark (see Matthew 4:16; 5:14–16; John 1:14; Romans 2:19).

Proverbs 4:20–21

pay attention: See also Proverbs 1:8, 23; 2:1; 5:1–2; 7:1–3; 8:1. The child should let these teachings change his personality, symbolized by his heart. Following wisdom for life needs a change of heart.

Proverbs 4:20–27

Wise people walk through life looking straight ahead.

Proverbs 4:22

Following a father's wise instructions leads to life and healing (see Proverbs 4:10).

Proverbs 4:23

In the Old Testament, the heart symbolizes the center of emotions, thoughts, and reasoning (for example, Genesis 6:5; Deuteronomy 4:29; Psalm 131:1). The heart plays a key role in the struggle between wisdom and foolishness, and between righteousness and evil (see Matthew 5:8; 13:15; John 12:40; Romans 6:17).

Proverbs 4:24

Proverbs teaches a lot about speech because words come from the heart. One basic lesson is to avoid bad speech, which includes lies, slander, gossip, and rumors (Proverbs 6:12; 17:4; 18:8).

Proverbs 5:1–2

Following instructions helps you make good choices. This is especially important when dealing with a woman who behaves immorally.

Proverbs 5:1–23

These instructions on loving one's wife and avoiding immoral women were originally for young men starting their careers (see also Proverbs 2:16–22; 7:1–27). This topic is also common in ancient Egyptian wisdom writings.

Proverbs 5:3–4

The lips of an immoral woman may seem sweet and tempting, but they are actually bitter and dangerous. Sexual activity often starts with a kiss, and flattering words can lure someone in.

Proverbs 5:5–6

A relationship with an immoral woman leads to death, just like a relationship with the woman named Folly (see Proverbs 9:13–18).

Proverbs 5:9–10

An illicit relationship may seem tempting, but it eventually causes shame. If the woman is a prostitute, the young man will have to pay her, losing income. If the woman is another man's wife, he might have to pay her husband (see Leviticus 20:10).

Proverbs 5:11

People in the ancient Near East were familiar with some sexually transmitted diseases. Leviticus 15:1–15 likely describes gonorrhea. Other Mesopotamian texts mention "the disease of intercourse" and the "disease of Ishtar" (goddess of love), which show symptoms of venereal diseases.

Proverbs 5:15–18

To drink from one's own well (see also Song 4:12, 15) means to enjoy sexual relations within marriage. Instead of spending sexual energy on immoral women, a man should build a healthy sexual relationship with his wife. Sex should not be shared with strangers. This honors marriage (Genesis 2:22–25) and follows the seventh commandment (Exodus 20:14 and Deuteronomy 5:18).

Proverbs 5:19

fawn: Compare with Song of Solomon 4:5.

Proverbs 5:21–23

Even if a man hides an illicit relationship from his family and society, the Lord knows. Adultery is a sin against God (Genesis 39:8–9).

Proverbs 5:22

Habitual sins are like ropes that trap and hold people.

Proverbs 5:23

He dies: Young men must practice self-control, as acting on forbidden sexual desires can lead to death.

Proverbs 6:1–5

To secure someone else's debt means to use your own possessions as a guarantee. Whether you do this to gain a friend's goodwill or to profit from a stranger (see Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:36–37; Deuteronomy 23:19–20), the risk is too high. It could lead to financial ruin. This warning is repeated in Proverbs 11:15; 17:18; 20:16; 22:26; 27:13.

Proverbs 6:3–5

free yourself: The risk of disaster is so high that escaping is a matter of life and death, like animals trapped.

Proverbs 6:6–11

- Lazy people sleep instead of preparing for what they need (see also Proverbs 24:33–34). They are the opposite of self-motivated and hardworking ants.
- Extra sleep and more slumber sarcastically describe a lazy person's ambition.

Proverbs 6:10–11

Laziness leads to poverty. It will arrive quickly and harshly, like when a robber or bandit attacks and steals. See parallel passage Proverbs 24:33–34.

Proverbs 6:12–15

Eyes…feet…fingers…heart: These body parts describe a person's overall character, not just a single foolish act.

Proverbs 6:13

Winking…speaking…pointing: These were signals used to deceive innocent people.

Proverbs 6:15

Even if bad people seem to succeed, they will face sudden punishment.

Proverbs 6:16–19

The first line shows a number, and the second line increases it by one. This method, called number parallelism, introduces a list of items. It often highlights the most important final item (see also Proverbs 30:15–23).

Proverbs 6:19

A false witness distorts the truth in court or in daily conversation.

Proverbs 6:20–35

This passage highlights the serious danger of having a relationship with another man's wife (see also Proverbs 1:8, 23; 2:16–22; 5:1–23; 7:1–27).

Proverbs 6:24–25

The immoral woman uses flattering words and physical beauty to attract young men.

Proverbs 6:26

Sleeping with a prostitute has consequences, and sleeping with another man's wife can be dangerous. Her husband may seek revenge (Proverbs 6:34–35), and God observes and judges.

Proverbs 6:27–29

walk on hot coals: Yes, this will cause his feet to blister. The results are terrible.

Proverbs 6:30–31

Sevenfold likely means "a large amount" because the law did not require such high repayment (see Exodus 22:1, 4, 9).

Proverbs 6:32–35

A thief might face severe punishment, even if he had a reason for his actions. However, his punishment is less severe than that of an adulterer, who has no excuse for his crime. A jealous husband will demand the maximum punishment allowed by law, which is death (Deuteronomy 22:22).

Proverbs 7:1–27

This is the final section in Proverbs 1–9 that warns about the dangers of promiscuous women (see also Proverbs 2:16–22; 5:1–23; 6:20–35).

Proverbs 7:2

guard my teachings as the apple of your eye: Or, with great care.

Proverbs 7:3

- The Old Testament uses the phrase "tie them to your fingers" as a reminder to remember important things, especially God's commands (Deuteronomy 6:8; 11:18).
- The New Living Translation's "write them deep within your heart" reflects the Hebrew saying write them on the tablet of your heart (see also Proverbs 3:3). Only obedience that comes from the heart will endure.

Proverbs 7:4

In Hebrew, sister is a term of endearment that shows closeness (see Song of Solomon 4:9–10).

Proverbs 7:5

Wisdom leaves no room for a woman who uses flattery to appeal to a young man's vanity.

Proverbs 7:6–7

Young men who are inexperienced and not set in their ways are open to learning. Each foolish act brings them closer to becoming fools.

Proverbs 7:6–23

The young man's father shares a story to explain his lesson about women with questionable morals.

Proverbs 7:9

Foolish actions are often associated with darkness (see Proverbs 4:18–19; Ecclesiastes 2:13–14).

Proverbs 7:10

The woman, dressed attractively, appears nice on the outside but has many problems inside.

Proverbs 7:12

Prostitutes often sought customers in public places like markets and on busy street corners (for example, Genesis 38:13–16).

Proverbs 7:14

The immoral woman follows religious rituals to appear good, but her actions show a corrupt heart.

Proverbs 7:16–17

She focuses on her bed and exotic perfumes like myrrh, aloes, and cinnamon, which have clear sexual implications (see Song of Solomon 4:13û14).

Proverbs 7:18

let us take our fill of love: see Song of Solomon 5:1.

Proverbs 7:21–23

The young man's unwise actions could endanger his life (see Proverbs 5:11; 6:32–35).

Proverbs 7:24–27

The father emphasizes thr lesson: An adulteress may seem attractive, and a relationship with her is tempting, but it will lead to harm or even death.

Proverbs 8:1–2

Wisdom speaks openly and publicly, inviting everyone to accept her gift of wisdom. Like a prophet, she wants everyone to listen to her words.

Proverbs 8:1–9.18

The first part of Proverbs reaches a peak when the son meets two women. Both invite the young man, and the reader, into a close relationship. The young man and the reader must choose between:

- The woman named Wisdom, who represents God's true wisdom (Proverbs 8:1–9:6)
- The woman named Folly (9:13–18), who represents worldly wisdom (1 Corinthians 1:18–2:16)

Both women's houses are on "the heights of the city" (Proverbs 9:3, 14), which suggests ancient temples. The choice is between the true God and false gods.

Proverbs 8:2

The hilltop and crossroads are easy for everyone to reach.

Proverbs 8:3

In ancient Near Eastern cities, the city gates had chambers for legal proceedings and business deals. It was a good place for Wisdom to reach many people.

Proverbs 8:6–9

Wisdom is linked to truth, understanding, and knowledge, which are correct, wholesome, simple, and clear. Wisdom dislikes deception, which is sneaky and dishonest (compare Proverbs 1:2–7; 6:16–19).

Proverbs 8:10–11

receive…rather: You must decide between pursuing money or valuables and seeking wisdom, which is much more valuable.

Proverbs 8:12

Only those with wisdom can have good judgment, knowledge, and discernment.

Proverbs 8:13

People who choose wisdom, meaning those who respect the Lord (see Proverbs 1:7; 9:10), will speak truthfully and kindly.

Proverbs 8:15–16

The best rulers use wisdom to guide them (for example, 1 Kings 3:16–28).

Proverbs 8:22–25

created me as His first course, before His works of old…From everlasting I was established: God's wisdom has always been. Here, wisdom is shown as a person, but it is not an actual person. Wisdom is part of God's character and nature. Unlike pagan gods, God does not need an outside advisor (see Isaiah 40:13–14). Jesus is the highest point of God's wisdom (see Colossians 1:15–17; 2:3).

Proverbs 8:27–29

God used his wisdom to create the world. Wisdom helps us understand how the world works and shows God's greatness.

Proverbs 8:30

craftsman: God's wisdom shaped creation, bringing order from chaos.

Proverbs 8:32–36

Wisdom gives great rewards to those who listen and follow it.

Proverbs 8:35–36

Life is the greatest reward for the wise. Rejecting wisdom leads to death. These verses refer to eternal life and death (see Luke 23:43; 1 Corinthians 15).

Proverbs 9:1

The number seven symbolizes greatness or completeness. Thus, the seven columns represent the greatness of Wisdom's house, where it resides.

Proverbs 9:1–6

In Proverbs 9:13–18, a competing invitation challenges this offer to join Wisdom for a lavish meal.

Proverbs 9:2

In the ancient Near East, people held a great banquet for a marriage, a military victory, or a treaty. Wisdom's celebration marks the start of a committed relationship with the listener.

Proverbs 9:3

In the ancient Near East, people built temples on high places above the city. Being wise means being dedicated to the Lord (see Proverbs 9:14 for comparison).

Proverbs 9:4

Wisdom appeals mainly to those who are naive and lack good judgment because they have not yet chosen between wisdom and foolishness. See Proverbs 9:16, where Foolishness copies and then distorts Wisdom's words.

Proverbs 9:6

Wisdom helps people handle life well.

Proverbs 9:7–9

These verses create a break between the invitations of Wisdom and Folly. The purpose might be to warn the simple (Proverbs 9:4) that inviting mockers and the wicked is often pointless. These people have already chosen their path and respond to Wisdom's advice with violence. In contrast, the wise appreciate and benefit from corrective advice.

Proverbs 9:10–12

fear of the LORD: Refer to study note on Proverbs 1:7.

Proverbs 9:13

The woman named Folly is loud: Fools speak loudly and shamelessly but say nothing smart.

Proverbs 9:13–18

The woman named Folly invites those who are naive and lack good judgment to join her banquet. Her invitation and advice oppose Wisdom's (Proverbs 9:1–6).

Proverbs 9:14

Traditionally, people built temples on the hills above the city. Folly represents false gods and goddesses who try to win the love and loyalty of God's people (compare Proverbs 9:2–3).

Proverbs 9:17

Just like Wisdom, Folly has prepared a banquet for her guests (see Proverbs 9:2–5). However, this meal is deceitful and immoral.

Proverbs 9:18

Folly's dinner guests end up in the grave, unlike the reward for Wisdom's guests (see Proverbs 9:6).

Proverbs 10:1

Godly parents feel joy or grief based on how well their child follows wise principles.

Proverbs 10:1–22.16

This section is called The Proverbs of Solomon. It mostly contains short pieces of advice and observations. These sayings often use antithetical parallelism to compare wisdom and righteousness with foolishness and wickedness. The proverbs seem to be arranged randomly, similar to Egyptian and Mesopotamian wisdom literature. Some proverbs repeat:

- Proverbs 6:10–11 and 24:33–34
- Proverbs 14:12 and 16:25
- Proverbs 18:8 and 26:22
- Proverbs 19:24 and 26:15
- Proverbs 20:16 and 27:13
- Proverbs 21:9 and 25:24
- Proverbs 22:3 and 27:12

Sometimes, a group of proverbs shares a similar theme (for example, Proverbs 16:1–11).

Proverbs 10:2

Ill-gotten treasures…righteousness: The book of Proverbs values good behavior more than money (see also Proverbs 11:18; 13:11, 22).

Proverbs 10:3

This proverb can be misused if people think outward results show someone's godliness. Job's three friends, for example, wrongly thought Job must have sinned to deserve his suffering (see Job 22:6–11).

Proverbs 10:4–5

Lazy people make unwise choices, but hard workers make wise decisions (see also Proverbs 10:26; 26:13–16).

Proverbs 10:7

the name of the wicked will rot: In ancient Israel, as in today's Middle East, honor and shame were strong motivators.

Proverbs 10:9

Paths symbolize life (see Proverbs 1:15).

Proverbs 10:10

- To ignore wrongdoing suggests approval of bad behavior instead of addressing it.
- foolish lips will come to ruin: The Berean Standard Bible follows the Hebrew version (the Masoretic Text). Some scholars think this wording might have been influenced by Proverbs 10:8. Instead, they follow the Greek version of the Old Testament (the Septuagint), which says, "the one who rebukes with confidence makes peace."

Proverbs 10:11

Like a fountain gives water to support life, the words of good people give life to listeners. In contrast, the hidden violent intentions in the words of bad people lead to death (see also Proverbs 10:6; James 3:1–12).

Proverbs 10:13

rod is for the back: People without sense harm themselves with their words. For information on physical discipline, see Proverbs 23:13–14.

Proverbs 10:15

While wealth can protect against problems, it can also cause them (Proverbs 13:8) and give a false sense of security (Proverbs 18:10–11).

Proverbs 10:17

Wise people welcome corrections to their thoughts or actions. They see discipline as a chance to become wiser.

Proverbs 10:19

People who talk too much often reveal their lack of knowledge and cause problems for themselves (see also Proverbs 10:17; 13:3; 17:28).

Proverbs 10:20

Words express what is in the heart.

Proverbs 10:25

The wicked may enjoy life's material blessings, but only for a short time, unlike the godly. Jesus also explained this truth (Matthew 7:24–27).

Proverbs 10:30

This saying relates to God's covenant promises to Israel (see Deuteronomy 28:1–14, 63–68). These connections are uncommon in Proverbs.

Proverbs 11:1

- Here, honest practices are used in business (see also Proverbs 16:11; 20:10, 23; Leviticus 19:35–37; Deut 25:13–15; Ezekiel 45:10; Hosea 12:7–8; Micah 6:11).
- Scales often had two metal bowls hanging from a crossbar. The currency unit, the shekel, comes from the verb meaning "to weigh" (see Amos 8:5–6).

Proverbs 11:2

Pride involves promoting oneself dishonestly, while humility means honestly recognizing one's strengths and weaknesses.

Proverbs 11:4

Living rightly, which comes from wisdom, is more important than wealth. There is nothing wrong with riches (Proverbs 10:15, 22; 14:24) if earned honestly (compare 13:11; 21:6; 22:16).

Proverbs 11:10

Our actions, whether good or bad, impact the entire city (see Ecclesiastes 8:9–13).

Proverbs 11:13

This view on gossip is echoed in Proverbs 20:19.

Proverbs 11:14

The future of a nation depends on wise decisions.

Proverbs 11:15

This message appears in Proverbs 6:1–5, 17:18, 20:16, 22:26, and 27:13.

Proverbs 11:16

Respect is a lasting reward for being kind, while wealth is a temporary prize for being ruthless (see also Proverbs 10:2; 11:18).

Proverbs 11:21

Good behavior positively impacts the next generation.

Proverbs 11:22

Discretion is the skill to distinguish right from wrong, beauty from ugliness, and good taste from bad taste.

Proverbs 11:23

In the short term, bad people might succeed and good people might face hardships, but the future will correct this imbalance.

Proverbs 11:24–26

Generous people who give freely to others will succeed, but those who hoard their money will lose it (see Proverbs 28:27; 2 Corinthians 9:6–9).

Proverbs 11:28

Money can be a blessing from God, but it is not guaranteed. Those who trust in God will thrive (see Psalm 1).

Proverbs 11:31

The suggested answer is that evil people will face punishment on earth.

Proverbs 12:4

- In other parts of Proverbs, a crown represents:
- Wealth (Proverbs 14:24)
- Long life (Proverbs 16:31)
- Grandchildren (17:6)
- decay (literally rot): A disgraceful wife is a serious and life-threatening issue.

Proverbs 12:7

The wicked may succeed for a short time, but they do not endure. The family of the righteous remains strong for generations.

Proverbs 12:8

Being sensible means thinking about the consequences before acting. A warped mind acts without thinking.

Proverbs 12:9

What is real matters more than how things look.

Proverbs 12:11

This proverb is repeated with a different ending in Proverbs 28:19.

Proverbs 12:12

Thieves can become violent at any time due to their instability. In contrast, godly people are well-grounded, and their relationships remain stable even in tough times.

Proverbs 12:15

Fools do not understand what wise people know: listening is the key to learning.

Proverbs 12:16

Staying calm helps a wise person think clearly and avoid actions that might start a fight.

Proverbs 12:17

This proverb's message is also in Proverbs 14:5.

Proverbs 13:1

A wise son heeds his father's discipline: Gaining wisdom needs discipline and correction.

Proverbs 13:3

Controlling what you say shows wisdom (see James 3:1–12).

Proverbs 13:7

Things are not always what they seem.

Proverbs 13:8

Money can be a blessing or a curse (see Proverbs 3:9–10; 21:6).

Proverbs 13:9

extinguished: Compare Proverbs 20:20; 24:20.

Proverbs 13:17

People mainly communicated through spoken messages. An unreliable messenger delivering the wrong message could cause many problems.

Proverbs 13:20

The people we spend time with influence us.

Proverbs 13:23

Hard work does not always lead to success (see Proverbs 10:426; 12:11; 13:4) because injustice exists in the world.

Proverbs 13:24

Punishment can help motivate learning. Discipline shows love, while not disciplining a child can show laziness (see also Proverbs 19:18; 23:13–14; 29:17).

Proverbs 14:1

Building or tearing down a home is a metaphor for making a family stronger or weaker.

Proverbs 14:2

- The path symbolizes life and behavior (see Proverbs 2:13, 20; 3:6; 4:11; 6:23).
- fears the LORD: See Proverbs 1:7.

Proverbs 14:3

People can use a foolish person's words against them.

Proverbs 14:4

It is easy to keep a stable clean if it is empty, but a farmer without an ox cannot harvest crops.

Proverbs 14:5

Honest speech and lies both come from a person's character. Compare Proverbs 12:17.

Proverbs 14:9

Wise people admit their mistakes and sins, which leads to change and making peace. Fools try to defend themselves by mocking guilt.

Proverbs 14:10

No one can completely understand another person's emotions (compare Psalm 103:14; Isaiah 63:9; Nahum 1:7; Romans 8:27). Bitterness and joy are opposites in emotions. This poetic device, called merism, refers to these extremes to cover all emotions in between.

Proverbs 14:11

A house is usually more stable than a tent, but wickedness destroys and tears down, while godliness builds up (Proverbs 14:1).

Proverbs 14:12

The best choice may not always appear correct at first glance (see Matthew 7:13–14). See the parallel passage in Proverbs 16:25

Proverbs 14:13

A person's appearance might not show their true feelings.

Proverbs 14:14

Backsliders act foolishly against what they know is good, right, and wise.

Proverbs 14:17

Short-tempered people do not think about the consequences before getting angry. Planners think ahead, but people dislike them for their harmful actions.

Proverbs 14:18

inherit folly: A person's true nature and attitude will eventually show in their behavior.

Proverbs 14:20

This proverb might advise moderation, suggesting having neither too little nor too much (Proverbs 30:7–9).

Proverbs 14:21

blessed is he who shows kindness to the poor: See also Proverbs 3:27–28; 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14.

Proverbs 14:24

This proverb shares a general idea. Sometimes, fools have wealth (Proverbs 10:2; 11:18), and poverty does not always come from foolishness (compare Proverbs 13:23; 16:8).

Proverbs 14:28

A king's success is shown by the well-being and growth of the people, not by wealth or military victory.

Proverbs 14:29

Wise people manage their emotions and express them in the right way.

Proverbs 14:30

A peaceful heart has settled its inner conflicts. Being free from jealousy is good for physical health.

Proverbs 14:31

- Wise people help the poor (compare Proverbs 11:24–26; 28:27; see Leviticus 19:9–10; Deuteronomy 15:11; 24:10–15; Isaiah 3:14–15; Jeremiah 2:34; see also James 2:1–13).
- taunts their Maker: See also Proverbs 17:5.

Proverbs 14:32

Proverbs rarely mentions life after death. Some scholars believe this verse means God gives courage to face death with dignity and calmness.

Proverbs 14:34

A great nation is not defined by wealth, power, or military victories (Proverbs 14:28) but by its moral values.

Proverbs 15:1

Controlling emotions and matching them to the situation helps others listen without reacting.

Proverbs 15:2

A wise teacher presents lessons in an engaging way. Rude behavior describes the poor teaching of a fool.

Proverbs 15:3

Knowing that the eyes of the Lord watch everywhere motivates wise behavior.

Proverbs 15:5

To be wise, learn from your mistakes.

Proverbs 15:6

God gives wealth to the righteous (Proverbs 10:22; see also 10:15 and 14:24). The wicked might also become wealthy, but it will cause problems instead of blessings (Proverbs 11:4, 18; 13:11; 21:6; 22:16).

Proverbs 15:8

God examines the heart's attitude behind sacrifices and prayers (see also Proverbs 21:27; Psalm 40:6–8; Micah 6:6–8).

Proverbs 15:11

- Sheol and Abaddon represent the fate of the dead. Sheol is where the dead reside, while Abaddon is another name for Sheol, suggesting punishment.
- God knows all secrets (see Psalm 139:1–12).

Proverbs 15:12

Mockers cannot become wise because they avoid criticism (compare Proverbs 10:17; 13:1, 10).

Proverbs 15:13

People's feelings influence how they present themselves (compare Proverbs 15:30).

Proverbs 15:14

Our preference for knowledge or trivial things shows if we are pursuing wisdom or foolishness.

Proverbs 15:15

Our personality shapes how we see life.

Proverbs 15:16

- A respectful fear of the Lord calms inner turmoil and brings peace.
- Better a little: See also Proverbs 16:8.

Proverbs 15:17

This proverb highlights the value of love over wealth. A big meal, like steak, is nice, but love is more important.

Proverbs 15:18

Managing your anger shows wisdom (see also James 1:19–20).

Proverbs 15:19

A lazy person can find many excuses, like a path blocked with briers, to avoid work (see Proverbs 10:4, 26; 12:11, 14; 13:4; 14:4).

Proverbs 15:22

A person might not consider every aspect of a problem. A wise person seeks advice from many people.

Proverbs 15:24

A wise person chooses life to avoid death.

Proverbs 15:25

Proud people believe they can take care of themselves. Widows in the ancient Near East were the opposite—very vulnerable and without support or protection.

Proverbs 15:29

The sincerity of your prayers determines if God hears them.

Proverbs 15:30

Our experiences, like seeing someone smile or hearing good news, can change how we feel. This, in turn, affects our demeanor (see Proverbs 15:13).

Proverbs 15:33

Fearing the Lord encourages humility because respecting God helps us see we are not self-sufficient.

Proverbs 16:1

Our plans will succeed only if God permits (see also Proverbs 16:9, 33; James 4:13–16).

Proverbs 16:2

God's judgment of right and wrong is what matters (see Genesis 8:21; 1 Samuel 13:14; 16:6–7; Luke 16:15). This saying is almost the same in Proverbs 21:2.

Proverbs 16:3

God should support our plans (Proverbs 16:1), so it is wise to ask for his help to achieve our goals (see James 4:13–16).

Proverbs 16:4

The wicked will face difficulties in life and after death. God controls everything (see also Romans 9:10–24; 2 Peter 2:9).

Proverbs 16:5

God dislikes proud people who do not follow the Lord's ways (Proverbs 16:3). They wrongly think they can succeed without help (Proverbs 16:1).

Proverbs 16:6

God's constant love and faithfulness are key in his covenant with Israel (see Exodus 15:13; 34:6–7; Numbers 14:18–19; Deuteronomy 7:9–11).

Proverbs 16:8

Better a little: See also Proverbs 15:16.

Proverbs 16:10

Divine wisdom is guidance from a divine source that helps the king make decisions (for example, 1 Kings 3:28; see also Psalm 72:2).

Proverbs 16:10–15

This series of sayings reflects on the king, who symbolizes God's power on Earth.

Proverbs 16:11

This proverb's message appears four times in the collection (see Proverbs 11:1; 20:10, 23).

Proverbs 16:12–13

These proverbs assume a wise and godly king (see Isaiah 9:6–7). Many of Israel's kings loved wrongdoing and hated truth, like Ahab in 1 Kings 21.

Proverbs 16:14–15

The king is powerful. People should avoid making him angry and try to earn his favor.

Proverbs 16:16

Having wisdom and good judgment can lead to wealth, but money cannot buy wisdom.

Proverbs 16:18

Those who resist God and rely on their own strength (Proverbs 16:5) are acting foolishly and harming themselves. Without God's help, no one has enough resources for life.

Proverbs 16:25

This saying is repeated in Proverbs 14:12.

Proverbs 16:27–29

Scoundrels, troublemakers, and violent people disrupt relationships by causing harm with their actions.

Proverbs 16:31

As godly people age, they become wiser, and their gray hair is like a crown (comparee Proverbs 4:9; 12:4; 17:6).

Proverbs 16:32

Patience and self-control are more valuable than using force.

Proverbs 16:33

The lot is cast: These dice were not for gambling. God used them to reveal his will (Exodus 28:30; see also Joshua 14:2; 1 Samuel 10:17–27; 14:40–43).

Proverbs 17:2

Wisdom is more important than privilege. If children act foolishly, a wise servant will become the leader of the household.

Proverbs 17:3

The Lord's refining fire (see Psalm 66:10; Jeremiah 9:7; Malachi 3:2–3) removes impurities from a person's heart, leaving only what is valuable (compare Proverbs 16:2; 21:2; 27:21).

Proverbs 17:4

Lies (Proverbs 6:16–19; 14:5, 25; 25:18), gossip (11:13; 18:8), and slander (10:18) twist the truth to harm others.

Proverbs 17:5

Mocking what God created is the same as mocking God.

Proverbs 17:6

- Only those blessed with a long life become grandparents. Continuing the family line shows God's blessing (see Genesis 12:1–3).
- father: This proverb applies to both fathers and mothers.

Proverbs 17:9

To have a good relationship, forgive others instead of focusing on their mistakes.

Proverbs 17:10

Wise people listen to gentle criticism and follow good advice. Even severe punishment will not change a foolish person.

Proverbs 17:11

Rebellion comes from the nature of evil people who resist the consequences of their actions.

Proverbs 17:12

This saying warns against teaching fools. A fool stuck in foolishness may respond with anger and violence.

Proverbs 17:14

release a flood: Once a quarrel starts, stopping it is hard. Avoid disputes whenever possible (see Proverbs 10:12; 15:18; 16:28; 20:3; 22:10; 26:21).

Proverbs 17:18

This message is repeated in Proverbs 6:1–5; 11:15; 20:16; 22:26; 27:13.

Proverbs 17:19

gate high: Overconfidence in winning a fight encourages people to start harmful arguments.

Proverbs 17:24

Wisdom is not natural; you must seek it. Wise people work hard to gain wisdom, but fools cannot stay focused.

Proverbs 17:25

A foolish son: This saying applies to both sons and daughters.

Proverbs 18:4

Words reflect a person's character, like water springs from the earth (see also Proverbs 10:20; 12:23; 16:23; compare James 3:10–12).

Proverbs 18:8

Rumors can be tempting to listen to and share, but they are harmful. See a parallel passage in Proverbs 26:22

Proverbs 18:10–11

In a troubled world, only the Lord can save. The rich might think their wealth is a strong defense, but money's power is limited (Proverbs 11:4; 13:8).

Proverbs 18:12

Arrogance breeds pride and causes failure because it blocks change when criticized. Humility learns from others and leads to the honor of success.

Proverbs 18:14

A spiritual or emotional problem, like a crushed spirit, can be more challenging than a physical illness.

Proverbs 18:16

See "Bribes" Theme Note.

Proverbs 18:17

It is important to listen to both sides of a disagreement. Only foolish people make quick decisions. Wise people take time to understand.

Proverbs 18:18

Casting the lot: Casting lots was once a valid way to seek God's will (Numbers 27:21; Joshua 18:6–10). The Lord decided how the lots would fall (Proverbs 16:33).

Proverbs 18:21

Life and death: Wise people speak thoughtfully (Proverbs 10:19; 11:12; 12:23) because they know words have consequences (13:3; 14:3).

Proverbs 18:23

God will punish the powerful who look down on the poor. Wise people help those in need (Proverbs 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14).

Proverbs 18:24

Some people who call themselves "friends" are not. Wise people look past appearances. They tell real friends from fake ones by their actions in tough times.

Proverbs 19:1

It is better to be honest, even if poor, because wealth from dishonesty does not last long (Proverbs 10:2) and will not protect from harm (11:4; see also 15:16–17; 16:8, 16; 17:1; 22:1; 28:6).

Proverbs 19:2

It is dangerous to act without understanding.

Proverbs 19:3

Fools blame the Lord instead of admitting their mistakes and actions.

Proverbs 19:5

God will ensure that liars receive punishment (see Proverbs 12:17, 19; 14:5, 25; 19:9).

Proverbs 19:8

We should seek wisdom because it helps us succeed.

Proverbs 19:9

The mention of a false witness (see also Proverbs 19:5) reminds us of the ninth commandment (Exodus 20:16), you shall not bear false witness.

Proverbs 19:12

A lion's roar warns of danger and possible violence (compare Proverbs 20:2). Dew on the grass is calming and helps plants grow (see Proverbs 16:14–15).

Proverbs 19:13–14

No decision is more important for a son than choosing a good wife (compare Proverbs 31:10–31). A poor choice causes pain (compare 10:1; 11:22; 12:4; 21:9, 19; 25:24; 27:15–17). A wise man will seek the Lord's help to find an understanding wife.

Proverbs 19:16

Following God's commandments, the law of Moses, keeps a person safe (see Deuteronomy 28:15–68).

Proverbs 19:18

Gaining wisdom needs discipline for everyone, including children (see Proverbs 10:17; 13:1, 10; 15:31–32; 17:10). The short-term sadness from discipline is worth avoiding disaster.

Proverbs 19:24

This proverb humorously highlights the foolishness of laziness (see also Proverbs 10:4–6, 26; 12:11, 27; 13:4; 15:19; 18:9). See the parallel passage in Proverbs 26:15.

Proverbs 19:25

A mocker cannot be helped (see study notes on Proverbs 1:22; 21:11). A leader should still punish him so the simpleminded learn a lesson.

Proverbs 19:26

See Exodus 20:12; 21:15, 17.

Proverbs 20:1

Too much alcohol affects a person's judgment. The Old Testament does not oppose drinking wine in moderation (Proverbs 3:10; 9:5; Psalm 104:14–15), but it strongly opposes excessive drinking (Proverbs 21:17; 23:29–35; 31:4–5).

Proverbs 20:2

Queen Esther was willing to risk her life and make the king angry (Esther 7).

Proverbs 20:6

True friends support you, even during tough times.

Proverbs 20:8

The king should embody wisdom and fairness.

Proverbs 20:9

Wise people know their own weaknesses. Pride stops people from seeing their faults (Proverbs 6:17–18; 11:2; 13:10; 15:33; 16:18; 18:12; see also 1 John 1:8–10).

Proverbs 20:10

Differing weights and unequal measures: Merchants should not cheat customers by using incorrect weights to measure grain (compare Proverbs 11:1; 16:11; 20:23).

Proverbs 20:12

The ability to watch and learn from experience is a special gift.

Proverbs 20:13

Laziness often results in poverty (see Proverbs 10:4–6, 26; 12:11; 13:4; 14:4; 15:19; 18:9; 19:15, 24; 20:4).

Proverbs 20:14

Sellers need to look beyond what buyers say to avoid being tricked.

Proverbs 20:16

- A wise lender asks for security or a deposit on a loan. A stranger was an Israelite unknown to the lender, who then required security. Proverbs advises the wise to avoid borrowing entirely (see Proverbs 6:1–2).
- This proverb's message is also found in Proverbs 6:1–5; 11:15; 17:18; 22:26.

Proverbs 20:19

This view on the gossip appears again in Proverbs 11:13.

Proverbs 20:21

If you receive an inheritance early in life, you might spend it all before you die, leaving nothing for later.

Proverbs 20:22

See also Romans 12:17–21.

Proverbs 20:23

This proverb's message appears in three other proverbs (see Proverbs 11:1; 16:11; 20:10).

Proverbs 20:24

God clearly guides our steps (see Proverbs 16:1, 9, 33). We do not need to understand why things happen. We should not lose hope because God is in control.

Proverbs 20:25

It is important to consider the cost before making a promise to God (see Judges 11:29–40; Ecclesiastes 5:4–6).

Proverbs 20:26

A king represents God on earth, so he should help good people and punish wrongdoers.

Proverbs 20:27

The Lord's light reaches the human spirit, and God sees deep into people's hearts (see Proverbs 16:2).

Proverbs 20:28

God's constant love and loyalty are linked to his agreement with his people (see Exodus 34:5–7; Deuteronomy 7:7–9). The king acts as God's representative on earth, so God will guard him (see 2 Samuel 7).

Proverbs 20:30

beatings cleanse the inmost parts: See Proverbs 13:24; 22:15; 23:13–14.

Proverbs 21:1

A king was the most powerful person in an ancient nation, and it seemed he could do anything he wanted. However, God guides the king's heart.

Proverbs 21:2

This proverb is almost exactly the same in Proverbs 16:2.

Proverbs 21:3

God wants worship to come from a sincere heart and lead to good actions (see Psalm 40:6–8; Micah 6:6–8).

Proverbs 21:4

Appearance (eyes), character (heart), and actions are all important. God dislikes pride (see Proverbs 6:17–18; 11:2; 13:10; 15:33; 16:18; 18:12).

Proverbs 21:8

The path of foolishness leads to death, while the road of wisdom leads to life.

Proverbs 21:9

A marriage that appears good from the outside, like in a beautiful home, is not fulfilling if it is full of arguments (see also Proverbs 21:19; 25:24; 27:15–17; compare 11:22; 12:4b). See the parallel passage in Proverbs 25:24

Proverbs 21:10

Evil people do not just do bad things; they are bad. No argument will change their behavior.

Proverbs 21:11

The simple-minded learn when they see a mocker punished (see Proverbs 1:22; 19:25). The wise do not need punishment threats because they already seek wisdom.

Proverbs 21:12

The Righteous One: God observes the wicked actions done in private and will punish them for their sins. Alternatively, the Righteous One could mean the wisdom of any righteous person.

Proverbs 21:15

God is fair, so he rewards good people and punishes bad ones. This is why good people love justice, and bad people fear it.

Proverbs 21:16

People with common sense can avoid life's dangers.

Proverbs 21:17

Spending on wine and luxury stops people from saving money. They choose to spend instead of save.

Proverbs 21:18

The wicked will get caught in the traps they set for others (Proverbs 26:27; see also 11:8).

Proverbs 21:19

Better to live in the desert: Compare Proverbs 21:9; 25:24.

Proverbs 21:20

See also to Proverbs 3:9–10, 15–16; 10:15, 16, 22; 14:24.

Proverbs 21:21

Righteousness and unfailing love are traits linked to Israel's agreement with God (see Exodus 34:5–7; Deuteronomy 7:9–11). The agreement promised life and honor to those who followed God's law (Deuteronomy 28:1–14).

Proverbs 21:22

A smart military planner can find ways to beat stronger armies. This shows that wisdom is better than just strength (compare Ecclesiastes 7:12; 9:13–18).

Proverbs 21:24

Mocker: See Proverbs 1:25–27 and 9:7–9. Also, see study note on Proverbs 1:22.

Proverbs 21:26

Generosity is a trait of the godly, while stinginess is a trait of fools (Proverbs 29:7, 14). Interestingly, the more you give, the more you receive (Proverbs 11:24).

Proverbs 21:30–31

Human wisdom is powerless against the Lord (see Proverbs 16:1, 3, 9, 33). Similarly, military power, symbolized by the horse, is powerless without the Lord's blessing.

Proverbs 22:1

A wise person will not risk their reputation for money.

Proverbs 22:2

Remembering that the Lord created both rich and poor helps stop the exploitation of the poor.

Proverbs 22:3

The idea of being careful appears in several proverbs (Proverbs 14:8, 15; 21:29). See the parallel passage in Proverbs 27:12.

Proverbs 22:4

Fear of the LORD (see Proverbs 1:7; 9:10) is closely linked with humility. A humble person understands he is not the center of the universe. Humility is more valuable than wealth (Proverbs 16:19; see also 11:2; 15:33; 18:12).

Proverbs 22:5

Living by deceit is risky. Corrupt people never know when others will discover their treachery or when it will backfire.

Proverbs 22:7

This warns against borrowing. Other proverbs advise against guaranteeing others' debts (Proverbs 6:1–2; 20:16).

Proverbs 22:11

Even a bad ruler wants advisers with a pure heart, meaning they are completely loyal and speak kindly.

Proverbs 22:12

This proverb reminds wise people (those with knowledge) that the Lord controls everything.

Proverbs 22:13

Among the many proverbs about laziness (Proverbs 10:4–6, 26; 12:11; 13:4; 14:4; 15:19; 18:9; 19:15, 24; 20:4, 13; 21:25; 26:13), this one is the funniest. Lazy people will invent any wild excuse to avoid working.

Proverbs 22:14

An immoral woman uses flattery and seduction to lure a young man into committing a sin.

Proverbs 22:15

We learn wisdom; it is not inherited or natural. Discipline is needed to turn foolishness into wisdom.

Proverbs 22:16

A person advances through hard work, not by taking advantage of the poor or bribing the wealthy (compare Proverbs 22:29).

Proverbs 22:17–21

Like the prologue in the book of Proverbs (Proverbs 1:2–7) and the introductions to the individual discourses (see Proverbs 1:8–9; 2:1–11), this section starts by encouraging listening. This wisdom goes beyond practical advice; it aims to inspire trust in the Lord.

Proverbs 22:17–24.22

This section is attributed to a group known as the wise, but their identity is unknown. There is a mention of thirty sayings (Proverbs 22:20). The wisdom sayings that follow can be divided into thirty sections. These sections are similar to an Egyptian work called the Instruction of Amenemope, which is also divided into thirty chapters.

Proverbs 22:20

thirty sayings: Early scribes observed that the Hebrew word for thirty was written in an unusual form (shlshwm) instead of the usual form (shlyshym). All early translations of the Old Testament, such as the Greek Septuagint, Latin Vulgate, and Syriac Peshitta, interpret it as thirty. However, some choose to translate the word as excellent sayings.

Proverbs 22:22–23

Saying 1: God protects the weak, including the poor. Those who are wealthy should be generous to the poor (Proverbs 11:24–26; 21:13; 22:9, 16; 28:27).

Proverbs 22:24–25

Saying 2: An angry or hot-tempered person cannot control their emotions and shows anger at the wrong times.

Proverbs 22:26–27

This proverb's message is also found in Proverbs 6:1–5; 11:15; 17:18; 20:16; 27:13.

Proverbs 22:28

Saying 4: In ancient times, stones marked property boundaries. Moving these markers was a serious offense (see also Proverbs 23:10; Deuteronomy 19:14).

Proverbs 22:29

Saying 5: People who improve their skills and work hard will get the best jobs and work for the best employers.

Proverbs 23:1–3

Saying 6: Many proverbs advise young men in government jobs. A ruler's rich food might tempt a newcomer to overeat due to lack of self-control. But he will be at risk when full.

Proverbs 23:4–5

Saying 7: Wealth can be a blessing from God (Proverbs 3:9–10, 15–16; 10:22), but some things in life matter more.

Proverbs 23:6–8

Proverbs highly values generosity (Proverbs 11:24–26; 21:13; 22:9).

Proverbs 23:9

Saying 9: Fools do not listen to advice (compare Proverbs 9:7–12; 10:18), so wise people do not waste their words (see Matthew 7:6).

Proverbs 23:10–11

- Saying 10: Wise people avoid unfair business practices and illegitimate gains (see Proverbs 22:28), knowing that the Lord will judge wrongdoing.
- Redeemer: The New Living Translation is likely correct in capitalizing the word Redeemer and identifying it with God, although it might refer to a human redeemer.

Proverbs 23:12

Saying 11: Listen carefully: Learning helps you improve (see Proverbs 10:17; 13:1, 10; 15:24, 31–32; 17:10; 19:24).

Proverbs 23:13–14

Saying 12: Refer to Proverbs 19:18; 29:17.

Proverbs 23:15–16

Saying 13: A wise parent feels joy when their child is wise (see Proverbs 10:1).

Proverbs 23:17–18

Saying 14: Sometimes sinners succeed, but the wise know that fearing the Lord brings true rewards (see Proverbs 1:7).

Proverbs 23:19–21

Saying 15: Discipline is essential for a wise and balanced life. Drinking too much (drunkards, see also Proverbs 23:29–35), overeating (gluttons, see also Proverbs 23:1–3), or oversleeping (see also Proverbs 10:5; 19:15) leads to poverty.

Proverbs 23:22–25

Saying 16: This saying encourages seeking the wisdom that both a godly father and mother offer. Unlike other ancient Near East wisdom texts, Proverbs credits wisdom to both parents (Proverbs 1:8; 6:20).

Proverbs 23:26–28

Saying 17: Falling for a promiscuous woman is a trap, not a benefit. Proverbs often warns against sexual relations outside of marriage (see Proverbs 5; 6:20–35; 7:1–27).

Proverbs 23:29–35

Saying 18: This saying highlights the foolishness of someone who drinks too much alcohol (see Proverbs 20:1).

Proverbs 24:1–2

Saying 19: See Proverbs 1:8–19.

Proverbs 24:3–4

Saying 20: See Proverbs 14:11.

Proverbs 24:5–6

Saying 21: See Proverbs 21:22.

Proverbs 24:7

Saying 22: Leaders need to be wise (see Proverbs 8:5–6).

Proverbs 24:8–9

Saying 23: Fools separate themselves from the community because they do bad things.

Proverbs 24:10

Saying 24: A wise person stays calm and strong when stressed (for example, Daniel 1:8–16; 3:1–18).

Proverbs 24:11–12

Saying 25: Wise people try to stop injustice and suffering (for example, Job 29:12–17).

Proverbs 24:13–14

Saying 26: Both honey and wisdom are sweet. Wisdom enriches the soul and creates more future opportunities.

Proverbs 24:15–16

Saying 27: Godly people do not let setbacks keep them down. • Seven times symbolizes “many times.”

Proverbs 24:17–18

Saying 28: This saying introduces the teaching of Jesus to love our enemies (Matthew 5:43–48).

Proverbs 24:19–20

- Saying 29: Do not envy the seeming success of the wicked (see Proverbs 24:1–2), because their success does not last.
- extinguished: Compare Proverbs 13:9; 20:20.

Proverbs 24:21–22

Saying 30: The king is linked to the Lord, showing his power and rule on earth (see 1 Samuel 12; Psalm 2).

Proverbs 24:23–25

Saying 1: Wise people make fair judgments (see Proverbs 6:19; 12:17; 19:28; 24:28–29; 25:18).

Proverbs 24:23–34

This addendum to the thirty sayings of the wise (Proverbs 22:17–24:22) includes five more sayings.

Proverbs 24:26

Saying 2: A true friend does not hide problems but honestly shows where you can improve. A wise person appreciates a friend’s advice.

Proverbs 24:27

Saying 3: A wise person finds a way to earn money before spending it on themselves.

Proverbs 24:28–29

Saying 4: Do not twist the truth, even for revenge (see Proverbs 6:19; 12:17; 14:25; 19:28; 24:23–24; 25:18).

Proverbs 24:30–34

Saying 5: Laziness and a love for sleep can lead to poverty (see Proverbs 10:4–5, 26; 12:11; 13:4; 15:19; 18:9; 19:15, 24; 20:4, 13).

Proverbs 24:33–34

This saying repeats Proverbs 6:10–11.

Proverbs 25:1–29.27

During King Hezekiah's reign from 728 to 686 BC, advisers gathered these proverbs of Solomon and added them to the collection.

Proverbs 25:2–3

This warning advises young men entering royal service that some things are beyond understanding, like the king's mysterious reasoning (for example, 2 Samuel 11:14–25; 24:3).

Proverbs 25:4–5

Just as silver is useful after removing impurities, the king's court can do justice when removing wicked people. A small amount of evil can ruin much good (Ecclesiastes 10:1).

Proverbs 25:6–7

To meet the king, a wise person will show humility instead of pride (compare Matthew 20:20–28).

Proverbs 25:7

Hasty actions often lead to regret.

Proverbs 25:9–10

See Proverbs 11:13 and 20:19.

Proverbs 25:11–12

Timely advice and valid criticism are valuable, beautiful, and rare (see also Proverbs 15:23; 26:7, 9). We should welcome them (see Proverbs 10:17; 13:1, 10; 15:24, 31–32; 17:10).

Proverbs 25:13

Snow would be a welcome relief in Israel's hot, dry summers (compare Proverbs 26:1). Trustworthy messengers refresh their employer by helping them plan for the future.

Proverbs 25:14

In Israel, rain is rare. When storm clouds appear but do not bring rain, it is like the disappointment of empty promises. Compare this to Jude's description of false teachers (Jude 1:12).

Proverbs 25:16–17

Honey is tasty and healthy in moderation (Proverbs 24:13–14), but too much can cause vomiting. This idea applies to other life areas. For example, visiting your neighbors is good, but do not visit too often.

Proverbs 25:18

Lying can lead to serious consequences (see Proverbs 6:16–19; 14:5, 25).

Proverbs 25:21–22

Surprisingly, showing kindness to an enemy works better than showing anger (see Romans 12:20).

Proverbs 25:24

This proverb appears again in Proverbs 21:9.

Proverbs 25:26

A spring or fountain that provides fresh water gives life. When good people let the wicked control them, what was once life-giving becomes harmful.

Proverbs 25:27–28

Wise people have self-control and are not easily dominated.

Proverbs 26:1

It is not right to honor fools.

Proverbs 26:2

Curses and blessings can truly impact people (see Genesis 27:1–41; 48:8–9, 15–20; Numbers 6:23–27), but a curse without cause does not work.

Proverbs 26:3

A fool is like a simple animal that needs strong guidance (see Proverbs 10:13; 14:3).

Proverbs 26:4–5

Proverbs often depend on the situation. Deciding whether to respond to foolish arguments depends on the type of fool and the situation.

Proverbs 26:7

A fool might know a proverb but not use it correctly. Compare with Proverbs 26:9.

Proverbs 26:9

A fool using a proverb incorrectly might cause harm. See Proverbs 26:7.

Proverbs 26:10

A fool or bystander might be lazy (see Proverbs 10:4–6) or incompetent (see 26:6–7). Employers should be cautious!

Proverbs 26:11

Even when foolish actions cause serious problems, a fool continues to act foolishly (Proverbs 17:10; see also 2 Peter 2:22).

Proverbs 26:12

Fools have hope because they might realize their mistakes and ask for help. However, those who believe they are wise will stay ignorant.

Proverbs 26:13–16

The slacker: See Proverbs 6:6–11; 10:4–5; 15:19; 22:13.

Proverbs 26:15

This proverb is the same as Proverbs 19:24.

Proverbs 26:17

Wise people stay out of other people's arguments (compare Proverbs 26:21).

Proverbs 26:18–19

Lies are very dangerous because they make people act on false information. Liars cannot later claim they were only joking (see Proverbs 6:16–19; 14:5, 25; 25:18).

Proverbs 26:20–21

A gossip and a quarrelsome person both add fuel to the fire of trouble and conflict.

Proverbs 26:22

This saying is repeated in Proverbs 18:8.

Proverbs 26:23–26

People sometimes hide bad intentions with flattery. Eventually, the true hatred of those who speak smoothly will be revealed.

Proverbs 26:27

People often face the negative outcomes they plan for others (see Proverbs 1:17–19).

Proverbs 27:1

We should plan (Proverbs 24:27), but our plans succeed only if God wills it (Proverbs 16:1, 3, 33; James 4:13–16). Only foolish people think they control the future.

Proverbs 27:2

The Hebrew word for praise comes from the same root as "brag" in Proverbs 27:1. Bragging, or self-praise, is unwise.

Proverbs 27:3

Fools create strong resentment with their foolish words and actions.

Proverbs 27:4

Anger can be dangerous, but a gentle answer can calm it (Proverbs 15:1). Jealousy is more difficult to resolve (Proverbs 6:34–35).

Proverbs 27:5

A rebuke can improve life by correcting harmful behavior (Proverbs 13:1; 14:6). Hidden, unexpressed love has no value.

Proverbs 27:6

Wounds from a friend come from a caring correction (Proverbs 27:5). They are better than flattery (kisses) from an enemy who wants to harm, not help.

Proverbs 27:7

Even the best teaching (honey) will be ignored if given at the wrong time. The key to real learning is the student's willingness to learn.

Proverbs 27:8

A person who leaves his family and home is more likely to find trouble than what he was looking for (for example, Luke 15:11–16).

Proverbs 27:9

Heartfelt advice from a close friend is very encouraging (see also Proverbs 27:6).

Proverbs 27:10

During a crisis, you might need help right away. It is important to have friends nearby and neighbors who can assist.

Proverbs 27:11

People often judge parents based on how their children behave in public.

Proverbs 27:12

This proverb is repeated in Proverbs 22:3.

Proverbs 27:13

This proverb appears again in Proverbs 20:16.

Proverbs 27:14

It is important to speak appropriately for the situation (compare Proverbs 15:23).

Proverbs 27:15

a contentious woman: Compare Proverbs 19:13; 21:9, 19; 25:24.

Proverbs 27:17

iron sharpens iron: Wisdom comes from interacting, often critically, with a good friend (see Proverbs 27:6, 9).

Proverbs 27:18

An employer values loyal workers who safeguard the employer's interests. Smart employers offer incentives for loyalty, like letting workers enjoy the benefits of their labor (see Deuteronomy 25:4; 1 Corinthians 9:7–10; 1 Timothy 5:17–18).

Proverbs 27:20

- Sheol and Abaddon: See study note on Proverbs 15:11.
- People never find true satisfaction in money, power, or pleasure.

Proverbs 27:21

A person who stays humble when praised shows a pure character (see Proverbs 17:3).

Proverbs 27:22

A fool's character is full of foolishness.

Proverbs 27:23–27

Agricultural property can provide food and clothing for generations. These resources need constant work and care, or they will vanish like riches.

Proverbs 28:1

The wicked face God's curse for breaking his covenant (see Leviticus 26:14–17, 36–37).

Proverbs 28:2

Wise leaders rule with justice and effectiveness (Proverbs 8:15–16).

Proverbs 28:4

Without laws, chaos happens and bad people thrive.

Proverbs 28:5

Bad people try to benefit by breaking the law. Justice makes sure they are punished, while good people receive rewards.

Proverbs 28:6

Virtue is more valuable than material wealth. This idea is repeated with a slightly different conclusion in Proverbs 19:1.

Proverbs 28:7

his father: This saying applies to both fathers and mothers.

Proverbs 28:8

The law forbade charging interest on loans to needy Israelites (Exodus 22:25; Leviticus 25:36; Deuteronomy 23:19). The rich were told to lend generously to the poor (Proverbs 3:27–28; 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14).

Proverbs 28:9

A person who ignores the law does not respect the Lord (Proverbs 1:7), the one who gives the law. That person's prayers are insincere, so why should God listen?

Proverbs 28:12

when the wicked rise: See also Proverbs 28:28.

Proverbs 28:13

Wise people admit their mistakes and wrongdoings and seek to correct them (see Psalm 32:1–5).

Proverbs 28:15

An unjust ruler will not help the poor. Like a roaring lion or an attacking bear, he ruins their lives.

Proverbs 28:17

- burdened by bloodguilt: See 1 Samuel 25:31; Romans 2:15; 13:5; compare Hebrews 10:22.
- let no one support him: Murder is so serious that a fine cannot replace the death penalty (see Numbers 35:32).

Proverbs 28:19

This proverb appears again with a different ending in Proverbs 12:11.

Proverbs 28:20

abound with blessings: You must earn wealth ethically, or it will cause harm and not last (see Proverbs 13:11, compare 10:2; 11:18; 13:22; 21:6).

Proverbs 28:21

Giving a wrong verdict because of a bribe is wrong (Proverbs 17:23; 22:16).

Proverbs 28:23

Wise people want honest feedback about their mistakes so they can improve (Proverbs 10:17; 13:1, 10; 15:24, 31–32).

Proverbs 28:24

Children who take advantage of their parents are wrong (see Exodus 20:12).

Proverbs 28:25

Greedy people fight to control situations to gain wealth. Trusting the Lord helps wise people stay calm and, surprisingly, find prosperity.

Proverbs 28:26

Wise people listen to others' advice, while those who only trust themselves act foolishly.

Proverbs 28:28

When the wicked come to power: See also Proverbs 28:12.

Proverbs 29:3

- A man's wisdom influences his parents (Proverbs 10:1; 15:20; 17:21).
- Spending money on prostitutes quickly wastes a man's wealth.

Proverbs 29:4

A fair king protects the rights of others. A ruler who takes bribes uses his position for personal benefit (see also Proverbs 17:23; 22:16; 28:21).

Proverbs 29:5

Flattery is often a trick to exploit someone (Proverbs 7:21–22; 26:23).

Proverbs 29:11

Wise people control their emotions and stay calm, even when stressed.

Proverbs 29:13

The oppressor should treat the poor more kindly because God created both of them (see also Proverbs 3:27; 11:24; 28:27; 29:7).

Proverbs 29:15

Wisdom is not natural; it must be learned.

Proverbs 29:18

Wise people follow God's law, which shows His will.

Proverbs 29:19

Sometimes, you may need to add clear consequences to instructions for discipline.

Proverbs 29:23

See Proverbs 6:17–18; 11:2; 13:10; 15:33; 16:18–19; 18:12; 19:20; 22:4.

Proverbs 29:24

he receives the oath: See Leviticus 5:1.

Proverbs 29:25

fear of man is a snare: See Proverbs 1:7; Luke 12:4–5.

Proverbs 30:1

- This superscription likely refers to all of Proverbs 30.
- Agur son of Jakeh: Besides this mention, Agur and Jakeh are not known. If "from Massa" is correct, as some translations use, then Agur was not an Israelite (the tribe of Massa is known from Assyrian texts).

Proverbs 30:1–3

Agur admits he does not know everything (compare Psalm 73:22, where the psalmist calls himself senseless). The first step toward wisdom is admitting our ignorance.

Proverbs 30:4–6

Unlike Agur's lack of knowledge and power, God's strength and wisdom are evident (compare Psalm 18:30). This is encouraging to Agur, as he knows God protects everyone who seeks Him.

Proverbs 30:7–9

Agur asks God for two things:

1. Help to avoid lying (compare Proverbs 6:16–19; 14:5, 25; 25:18; 26:18–19)
2. To not have too much or too little

Being rich (Proverbs 3:9–10, 15–16; 10:15, 22) or poor (3:27; 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14) is not sinful, but Agur wisely wants to avoid the problems of both.

Proverbs 30:11–14

These verses describe traits that wise people dislike. Fools:

- Disrespect their parents (Proverbs 10:1; 20:20; Exodus 20:12; Deuteronomy 5:16)
- Deceive themselves (Proverbs 8:7)
- Think they are clean when they are not (Proverbs 20:9)
- Are proud (Proverbs 6:17–18; 11:2; 13:10; 15:33; 16:18; 18:12; 19:20; 29:23)
- Hurt others with their words (teeth like swords, see Proverbs 25:18)
- Harm the poor (Proverbs 3:27; 11:24; 28:27; 29:7, 14)

Proverbs 30:15–16

- The number parallelism (three...four) is a method to list poetic examples. This list shows powers that are never satisfied and often dangerous. See also Proverbs 30:18–19, 21–23, 29–31.
- The grave, representing death, never seems to have enough—people keep dying (Proverbs 27:20).
- barren womb: Women unable to have children often long for them, like Sarah before Isaac, Rebekah before Esau and Jacob, and Hannah before Samuel.
- The thirsty desert and a fire consume everything in their path.

Proverbs 30:17

People who are unkind to their parents may face a harsh fate (see Proverbs 10:1; 19:26; 28:24; 29:3; 30:11).

Proverbs 30:18–19

The writer is amazed at how one thing affects another.

Proverbs 30:20

The writer is shocked by sex outside of marriage.

Proverbs 30:21–23

- This proverb lists four things that make the earth tremble because they disrupt the natural order.
- who is filled with food: In the ancient Near East, as in many non-industrialized parts of the world today, having enough food was a sign of prosperity.

Proverbs 30:24–28

Here is another example of number parallelism: small, seemingly insignificant animals can be surprisingly powerful and resourceful.

Proverbs 31:1–9

- Lemuel, like Agur, might have been from Massa (see study note on Proverbs 30:1). Lemuel's mother teaches him to control his desires, especially for women and alcohol, so he can rule fairly.
- Besides this passage, we know nothing about Lemuel.

Proverbs 31:2–3

The advice to avoid wasting energy on desire for women repeats earlier warnings (Proverbs 5; 6:20–35; 7:1–27).

Proverbs 31:4–7

Drinking too much wine dulls the senses. A king needs to stay alert and should not drink too much alcohol.

Proverbs 31:8–9

Instead of drinking wine (Proverbs 31:4–7), the king should defend those who cannot protect themselves.

Proverbs 31:10–12

Without God's help, finding a virtuous and capable wife is impossible (Proverbs 18:22). Such a woman, like wisdom, is more precious than rubies (compare Proverbs 3:15).

Proverbs 31:10–31

Proverbs concludes with a strong poem honoring the virtuous wife. The acrostic format makes it feel complete and helps students learn.

Proverbs 31:13–15

The wife works to provide food and clothing for her family.

Proverbs 31:16–18

An excellent wife participates in business activities outside her home.

Proverbs 31:19–21

A virtuous wife is generous to the poor, which is also a trait of wise people (Proverbs 11:24–26; 21:13; 22:9, 16, 22–23; 28:27).

Proverbs 31:22–24

A hardworking wife helps her husband stand out among community leaders. In ancient Israel, civic leaders met at the city gates to hold trials and make decisions.

Proverbs 31:25–27

The noble wife shows wisdom. She stays calm when facing the unknown. She offers advice in a charming way.

Proverbs 31:28–29

The people who know the woman best speak about her character, skills, and accomplishments.

Proverbs 31:30–31

The book ends as it started, emphasizing the importance of fearing the Lord (see Proverbs 1:7). A woman's character matters more than her physical beauty.